

UAE & Saudi Arabia Salary & Hiring Guide

2026

Salary benchmarks, hiring outlook and talent intelligence for employers and candidates.

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2026 GCC SALARY & HIRING GUIDE

Two world-class career markets. One exceptional region.

The UAE and Saudi Arabia sit among the world's most dynamic employment markets, combining global business exposure, ambitious growth and high-impact opportunities across specialist, transformation and leadership roles.

UAE**Global Talent Hub**

A globally connected market with deep talent pools, diverse employers and strong demand for high-impact specialists and proven leaders.

Saudi Arabia**High-Growth**

Major investment and transformation continue to create high-value opportunities for senior and specialist capability.

Compensation**Role-specific**

Live role benchmarking gives the clearest view. Scope, sector, specialist demand and package design shape the real range.

Generalist Talent**Broad Market**

Finance, HR and mainstream commercial hiring benefit from broad, internationally experienced talent pools.

Specialist Talent**High Demand**

Cyber, AI, enterprise architecture, cloud, ERP transformation and major-project leadership continue to command strong demand.

Executive Search**Quality-Led**

Boards and leadership teams value transformation track record, regional context and measurable delivery.

ION TALENT VIEW**A region where ambitious careers accelerate.**

The UAE and Saudi Arabia attract outstanding talent from around the world through global business exposure, ambitious growth, cultural richness and the chance to work at exceptional scale. Both offer career-defining opportunities and globally connected places to live and work.

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Two global career hubs. Distinct opportunities.

Dubai and Riyadh are both globally connected career destinations. The right benchmark reflects role scope, sector, local workforce planning and the distinct strengths of each market.

DIMENSION	UAE	SAUDI ARABIA
Hiring climate	Active and globally competitive	High-growth and globally competitive
Generalist candidate supply	Deep and international	Strong and expanding
Specialist availability	Strong senior-level demand	Strong demand across key categories
Compensation dynamics	Driven by scope and specialist demand	Strong in growth and transformation roles
Workforce planning	Local workforce planning	Local workforce and role planning
Mobility	Global talent hub	Major international career destination
Executive hiring	Deep regional and global pool	Leadership and transformation depth

Workforce planning

Build local workforce requirements into search design early. Role classification, workforce mix and hiring sequence can shape the available market and final package.

Candidate mobility

The UAE and Saudi Arabia offer outstanding international career opportunities. Moves between the two are strongest when role scope, visibility, lifestyle fit and long-term career value align.

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Construction, engineering & project delivery

Major programmes, infrastructure, real estate and industrial investment keep project-delivery leadership central to GCC hiring. The strongest premium sits with candidates who can combine technical depth, commercial control and delivery at scale.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Project Manager	AED 25-45k / month AED 300-540k / year	SAR 25-45k / month SAR 300-540k / year
Construction Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-50k / month SAR 360-600k / year
Engineering Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Commercial / Contracts Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Planning / Project Controls Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-50k / month SAR 360-600k / year
Construction Director	AED 50-70k / month AED 600-840k / year	SAR 50-80k / month SAR 600-960k / year
Project / Programme Director	AED 55-80k / month AED 660-960k / year	SAR 60-90k / month SAR 720-1,080k / year

Typical roles also include Design Manager, MEP leadership, Quantity Surveying, HSE leadership, Civil / Structural leadership and specialist engineering disciplines. Sector, project value and client-side vs contractor scope can move pay materially.

ION TALENT VIEW**DEMAND: HIGH****AVAILABILITY: MODERATE / TIGHT**

Project and construction management talent is broad at mid-level, while demand is strongest for project directors, commercial leaders, project controls specialists and engineering leaders with major-programme, complex stakeholder or client-side experience.

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Finance & accounting

Finance hiring remains broad, but the strongest candidates increasingly combine technical control with transformation, commercial partnership and stakeholder influence.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Financial Analyst	AED 15-25k / month AED 180-300k / year	SAR 15-25k / month SAR 180-300k / year
Finance Manager	AED 25-40k / month AED 300-480k / year	SAR 25-40k / month SAR 300-480k / year
Financial Controller	AED 25-50k / month AED 300-600k / year	SAR 35-50k / month SAR 420-600k / year
Head / Chief Internal Audit	AED 40-70k / month AED 480-840k / year	SAR 50-75k / month SAR 600-900k / year
Finance Director	AED 50-85k / month AED 600-1,020k / year	SAR 55-80k / month SAR 660-960k / year
Chief Financial Officer	AED 65-110k / month AED 780-1,320k / year	SAR 85-140k / month SAR 1,020-1,680k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: STEADY / HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE

Candidate supply is healthy at many levels. Demand is strongest around transformation-led finance leaders, high-quality FP&A and business partnering, specialist audit and leaders with credible sector depth. In Saudi Arabia, early workforce planning adds another important layer to search strategy.

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Sales & commercial

Commercial hiring rewards proof: market access, pipeline creation, enterprise deal cycles and the ability to convert opportunity into revenue in a crowded GCC market.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Key Account Manager	AED 15-30k / month AED 180-360k / year	SAR 20-30k / month SAR 240-360k / year
Business Development Manager	AED 18-30k / month AED 216-360k / year	SAR 25-35k / month SAR 300-420k / year
Sales Manager	AED 18-35k / month AED 216-420k / year	SAR 25-35k / month SAR 300-420k / year
Business Development Director	AED 30-50k / month AED 360-600k / year	SAR 50-60k / month SAR 600-720k / year
Sales Director	AED 30-60k / month AED 360-720k / year	SAR 55-65k / month SAR 660-780k / year
VP Sales / Commercial Director	AED 50-75k / month AED 600-900k / year	SAR 65-75k / month SAR 780-900k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MIXED

Generalist sales profiles are broad, while proven enterprise and solutions sellers command a premium. Strong candidates can evidence account growth, new-logo wins, complex deal cycles and sector access. In Saudi Arabia, workforce requirements should be checked before the search strategy is finalised.

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HR & people

People functions are balancing cost discipline with rising expectations around workforce planning, organisation design, reward and transformation.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
HR Generalist / Advisor	AED 18-25k / month AED 216-300k / year	SAR 18-25k / month SAR 216-300k / year
Talent Acquisition Manager	AED 30-40k / month AED 360-480k / year	SAR 30-40k / month SAR 360-480k / year
HR Business Partner	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
HR Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
Reward / L&D Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-50k / month SAR 420-600k / year
HR Director	AED 50-80k / month AED 600-960k / year	SAR 55-95k / month SAR 660-1,140k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: SELECTIVE

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE

Senior HR value is shifting toward workforce strategy, organisation design, reward, local talent development and credible partnering with business leadership. Generalist pools are broad, particularly in the UAE.

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Project, programme & transformation

Corporate transformation, operating-model change and portfolio delivery require more than project tenure. Employers are paying for governance, adoption and executive-level delivery confidence.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Project Manager	AED 25-40k / month AED 300-480k / year	SAR 25-40k / month SAR 300-480k / year
PMO Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
Programme Manager	AED 35-55k / month AED 420-660k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Transformation Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Head of PMO	AED 45-65k / month AED 540-780k / year	SAR 45-70k / month SAR 540-840k / year
Transformation Director	AED 50-75k / month AED 600-900k / year	SAR 55-80k / month SAR 660-960k / year
Strategy / Transformation Director	AED 55-85k / month AED 660-1,020k / year	SAR 60-90k / month SAR 720-1,080k / year

ION TALENT VIEW**DEMAND: HIGH****AVAILABILITY: MODERATE / TIGHT**

The strongest candidates can translate strategy into a controlled delivery portfolio, influence senior stakeholders and show measurable adoption. Demand is strongest for large-scale transformation leaders with cross-functional ownership and a track record beyond a single system implementation.

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Technology, digital & cybersecurity

Technology is deep enough to deserve extra detail, but the guide keeps it to two pages. On this page: engineering delivery and security leadership.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Software Engineer / Developer - mid	AED 20-30k / month AED 240-360k / year	SAR 20-35k / month SAR 240-420k / year
Engineering Manager	AED 35-60k / month AED 420-720k / year	SAR 40-50k / month SAR 480-600k / year
VP / Director of Engineering	AED 55-85k / month AED 660-1,020k / year	SAR 50-90k / month SAR 600-1,080k / year
Information Security Engineer	AED 20-45k / month AED 240-540k / year	SAR 20-40k / month SAR 240-480k / year
Security / InfoSec Architect	AED 25-60k / month AED 300-720k / year	SAR 30-65k / month SAR 360-780k / year
Head of Information Security	AED 35-70k / month AED 420-840k / year	SAR 45-70k / month SAR 540-840k / year
Chief Information Security Officer	AED 50-100k / month AED 600-1,200k / year	SAR 65-160k / month SAR 780-1,920k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: VERY HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE / TIGHT

The broad engineering market is deeper than the architecture and security-leadership market. Demand rises when technical depth is combined with enterprise stakeholder ownership, regulated-sector context, critical infrastructure or transformation at scale.

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Cloud, data, AI, enterprise architecture & ERP

Specialist demand is strongest in production AI, cloud architecture, enterprise design and enterprise-platform transformation.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Cloud Engineer	AED 15-40k / month AED 180-480k / year	SAR 20-35k / month SAR 240-420k / year
Cloud Architect	AED 40-60k / month AED 480-720k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
Data Engineer	AED 20-35k / month AED 240-420k / year	SAR 20-35k / month SAR 240-420k / year
AI / Machine Learning Engineer	AED 25-60k / month AED 300-720k / year	SAR 30-60k / month SAR 360-720k / year
Head of Data / Analytics	AED 50-75k / month AED 600-900k / year	SAR 50-75k / month SAR 600-900k / year
Enterprise Architect	AED 40-60k / month AED 480-720k / year	SAR 45-75k / month SAR 540-900k / year
ERP / SAP / Oracle Lead	AED 30-50k / month AED 360-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Head of Enterprise Applications	AED 50-70k / month AED 600-840k / year	SAR 40-70k / month SAR 480-840k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: VERY HIGH

AVAILABILITY: TIGHT

Employers are separating tool familiarity from production capability. The premium sits with candidates who can design at enterprise scale, govern complexity and show deployed outcomes. SAP S/4HANA, Oracle Fusion, cloud security and enterprise architecture remain especially search-intensive.

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Executive & C-Suite

Executive ranges are deliberately broad. Ownership model, scale, mandate, governance load, sector and variable / equity design can change total reward materially.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK Fixed monthly cash only. Bonus, equity / LTI and other benefits sit outside the table.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Chief Financial Officer	AED 65-110k / month AED 780-1,320k / year	SAR 85-140k / month SAR 1,020-1,680k / year
Chief Information Officer	AED 65-80k / month AED 780-960k / year	SAR 90-200k / month SAR 1,080-2,400k / year
Chief Technology Officer	AED 60-150k / month AED 720-1,800k / year	SAR 60-180k / month SAR 720-2,160k / year
Chief Information Security Officer	AED 50-100k / month AED 600-1,200k / year	SAR 65-160k / month SAR 780-1,920k / year
Chief Human Resources Officer	AED 85-150k / month AED 1,020-1,800k / year	SAR 100-140k / month SAR 1,200-1,680k / year
Chief Marketing Officer	AED 70-100k / month AED 840-1,200k / year	SAR 95-180k / month SAR 1,140-2,160k / year
Managing Director / General Manager	AED 70-120k / month AED 840-1,440k / year	SAR 80-150k / month SAR 960-1,800k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: SELECTIVE

AVAILABILITY: TIGHT AT PROVEN SCALE

Boards and leadership teams are placing more weight on transformation track record, succession depth, local context and measurable delivery. In Saudi Arabia, senior hiring increasingly benefits from an explicit leadership succession plan alongside immediate capability.

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Where specialist demand is strongest.

The most competitive GCC searches combine specialist capability with high-impact mandates. These are areas where proven experience can command a premium and create exceptional career opportunities.

01

AI / production ML

Deployment, governance and business adoption

02

Cyber & cloud security

Architecture, identity, DevSecOps and regulated environments

03

Enterprise architecture

Technology depth plus enterprise stakeholder ownership

04

ERP transformation

S/4HANA, Oracle Fusion and multi-entity delivery

05

Major-project leadership

Project directors, commercial leaders and project controls

06

Enterprise sales

Proven GCC revenue, complex deal cycles and sector access

07

Transformation leadership

Cross-functional ownership, governance and adoption

08

Executive leadership

Scale, local context and measurable transformation track record

CANDIDATE MOBILITY · ION TALENT VIEW

Saudi Arabia: a career move built on opportunity.

Saudi Arabia offers exceptional scope, visibility and international exposure across some of the region's most ambitious programmes. The strongest moves combine meaningful responsibility, career progression, lifestyle fit and a well-designed total package.

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Package design matters more in 2026.

Salary remains central, but candidates increasingly evaluate the entire proposition: mandate, fixed cash, bonus, benefits, relocation, flexibility and career value.

UAE package design

The UAE offers one of the region's deepest and most international professional markets. Clear fixed cash, bonus, medical, education, travel and equity components help candidates compare the full value of an opportunity.

Saudi package design

Saudi Arabia offers exceptional scope for professionals seeking scale, responsibility and exposure to fast-moving transformation. Strong packages align fixed cash with role mandate, benefits, mobility support and career value.

UAE workforce planning

Build local workforce requirements into hiring plans early. Validate the applicable framework for the entity and role before the search launches.

Saudi workforce planning

Align role classification and workforce planning with current local requirements before search launch, particularly in functions with role-level requirements.

ION TALENT VIEW

Build the proposition before you brief the market.

The strongest hiring outcomes come from clear role scope, an agreed compensation envelope and early workforce planning. That creates confidence, improves candidate experience and helps employers move decisively when they find the right profile.

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How to use the guide.

Salary data is useful only when it changes a hiring or career decision. These are the practical implications ION Talent would take into a live mandate.

FOR EMPLOYERS

Build the offer before the shortlist.

- **Benchmark scope, not title.**
Team size, reporting line, budget and mandate can move the range materially.
- **Separate fixed and variable cash.**
State what is included in the monthly figure and what sits outside it.
- **Build workforce planning in early.**
Validate role requirements before search launch.
- **Move decisively on high-demand profiles.**
AI, cyber, architecture, ERP, major-project and transformation talent can move quickly.
- **Design a compelling Saudi proposition.**
Housing, education, flights, medical, role scope and family logistics all shape total value.
- **Use live market mapping.**
The narrower the talent pool, the less useful a generic salary range becomes.

FOR CANDIDATES

Sell impact, not just experience.

- **Match your benchmark to the role's real scope.**
Title alone is a poor guide to value.
- **Compare total package.**
Fixed cash is only one part of GCC compensation, especially for relocation and executive roles.
- **Quantify outcomes.**
Revenue, savings, delivery speed, risk reduction and transformation scale travel better than generic responsibilities.
- **Make specialist capability concrete.**
Employers want evidence of production use, judgment and business adoption.
- **Understand local workforce requirements.**
Role requirements can shape the live market for a title.
- **For Saudi moves, evaluate scope as well as reward.**
Decision authority and career trajectory can matter as much as a marginal uplift.

ONE RULE TO KEEP

A salary guide is a starting point, not a substitute for live market mapping.

The narrower the talent pool, the more useful live search intelligence becomes: who is actually available, what they are earning, what they will move for and what competing employers are offering.

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How to read the salary benchmarks.

- **Compensation basis:** ranges represent typical fixed monthly cash/package benchmarks in AED or SAR. They are not a guaranteed base salary and generally exclude bonus, equity / LTI and non-fixed benefits.
- **Role selection:** representative roles were chosen around ION Talent's target functions and seniority levels. Titles are normalised where market naming differs between employers.
- **Range construction:** bands synthesise current market evidence into practical hiring ranges rather than false point estimates. Wider bands reflect genuine variation in mandate, sector, scale and ownership.
- **Annual figures:** monthly range x 12. No exchange-rate conversion is used between AED and SAR.
- **Market commentary:** commentary reflects ION Talent's interpretation of 2026 hiring conditions and should be used alongside live search intelligence.
- **Research cut-off:** 9 September 2026.

Disclaimer

This guide is general market information, not legal, tax, immigration or compensation advice. Salary outcomes depend on company size, sector, location, experience, applicable workforce requirements, role scope, benefits and market timing. Local workforce rules can be role- and establishment-specific and may change. Employers should validate current requirements before making employment decisions.

ION Talent

Hiring in the UAE or Saudi Arabia?

ION Talent combines direct search, live market mapping and practical compensation intelligence to help employers hire senior, specialist and high-impact talent.

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